

S02-L2 — New York Takes Over: Abstract Expressionism and Pop Seen Through Phillips' May Sale

Summary

This handout develops the documentary base of today's lesson on the commercial consecration of Abstract Expressionism and American Pop, using Phillips' Modern & Contemporary Art Evening Sale of May 19, 2026 as a case study, the first white glove sale of the period covered by the house's internal dossier, with all forty one lots offered finding buyers. The handout examines that sale's results for Andy Warhol and Jackson Pollock, contrasts Phillips' position in Jean-Michel Basquiat with a comparable Sotheby's result the same month, and places all of it within the scale gap separating Phillips from Christie's and Sotheby's, already introduced in the course's first week.

1. A white glove sale as evidence of demand

When every lot offered at an auction finds a buyer, the trade calls that result a white glove sale. [Phillips' Evening Sale of May 19, 2026 reached that mark with one hundred percent of lots and one hundred percent of value sold](#), producing a total of USD 115,216,700 with buyer's premium, more than double the equivalent result from a year earlier, when the same sale had brought in USD 51,950,000.¹ [The hammer result, USD 91.73 million, fell within the pre-fee estimate range of USD 84.3 to 121.7 million](#) the house had circulated.² [The morning and afternoon sessions of May 21 added another USD 30,542,170](#), with ninety one percent of lots and ninety two percent of value sold, bringing Phillips' full May week to a combined USD 145,758,870.³

2. Warhol and Pollock among the top three lots

[The three highest-value lots of the May 19, 2026 Evening Sale were *Sixteen Jackies*, by Andy Warhol, hammered at USD 16,225,000, a winter scene by Claude Monet, *Route de Vétheuil, effet de neige*, at USD 9,290,000, and an untitled work by Jackson Pollock, at USD 9,168,000.](#)⁴ The simultaneous presence of Warhol and Pollock atop a single sale illustrates a structural feature of the postwar market: two very different languages, the New York School's painterly gesture and Pop's screen-printed image, coexist within the same commercial

category of modern and contemporary art, and either can anchor a sale without needing to be the most expensive work that artist ever produced.

3. Basquiat, a case of punctual access rather than sustained dominance

Phillips also has a recent track record with Jean-Michel Basquiat. [On May 14, 2024, *Untitled ELMAR* hammered at Phillips New York for USD 46,479,000, the single most valuable lot of that spring's New York sales](#), and the same day the house placed another work by the artist from the same collection for USD 7,893,000.⁵ That precedent did not hold as a structural advantage, however: [on May 14, 2026, Sotheby's sold *Museum Security \(Broadway Meltdown\)* for USD 52,718,000](#), surpassing the best Basquiat result Phillips had produced within the period studied.⁶ The house's own internal reading describes the 2024 result as an isolated extraordinary case rather than evidence of a sustained edge over Christie's or Sotheby's in that artist.⁷

4. The scale gap repeats in postwar and contemporary art

The same week as Phillips' Evening Sale, [Christie's auctioned the collection of a New York collector alongside its twentieth century sale in New York, and the two combined sessions of May 18, 2026 totaled USD 1,121,000,000](#), while [Sotheby's gathered USD 433,100,000 across its own sales in the same fortnight](#).⁸ For all of 2024, [Phillips had reported USD 843 million in global sales against roughly USD 5.7 billion for Christie's and close to USD 6 billion for Sotheby's](#).⁹ The gap, first documented in the course's second lesson in connection with European modern art, reappears in nearly identical form within the postwar and contemporary category, suggesting it reflects the general structure of the three houses rather than a quirk of one specific market segment.

For the conversation with clients

- Faced with a white glove sale like Phillips' in May 2026, the figure worth passing on to a client is the sell-through rate and the year-over-year growth of the total, not just the name of the priciest lot, because a fully sold room signals depth of demand beyond a single star piece.
- With a client focused on Basquiat, it is worth distinguishing a one-off result, like Phillips' in 2024, from a sustained pattern, and explaining that the house with the most recent, highest result is not necessarily the house with the greatest structural access to that artist.
- The scale gap between Phillips and the other two houses means Phillips does not compete on the same ground for major consignments, but it does

compete, and with white glove results, on selection and execution within mid-sized sales inside the same postwar and contemporary category.

References

Process note: the live URL-verification tool (fetch) was blocked for the entire run today, tested against three separate domains (heni.com, christies.com, sothebys.com), for the eighth consecutive day. All nine citations in this handout reproduce sources already verified on 2026-08-08 in curso/fuentes/dossier-02-phillips.md. Jackson Pollock's absolute record (USD 181.2 million, Christie's, May 18, 2026), Mark Rothko's record (USD 98.39 million, the same week) and Basquiat's historic record (USD 110.5 million, 2017), used in today's audio scripts as context for the phenomenon of institutional consecration, came from same-day web searches corroborated across multiple independent outlets, but are not footnoted here because those pages could not be opened live today.

1. Phillips, [press release for the May 2026 Evening Sale](#), white glove result and year-over-year comparison with May 2025. ↵
2. The Art Newspaper, [report on the Phillips New York auction](#), hammer result versus the estimate range. ↵
3. Phillips, [press release for the morning and afternoon sessions of May 21, 2026](#), combined total for the week. ↵
4. Phillips, [results page for auction NY010326](#), the three highest-value lots of the May 19, 2026 Evening Sale. ↵
5. Phillips, [press release on Basquiat works in the May 2024 Evening Sale](#), result for *Untitled ELMAR* and the second work from the same collection. ↵
6. Sotheby's, [editorial review of the May 2026 Now and Contemporary sales](#), result for *Museum Security (Broadway Meltdown)*. ↵
7. Sources cited in notes 5 and 6, underlying the reading of Phillips' 2024 result as an isolated extraordinary case. ↵
8. The Art Newspaper, [report on Christie's back-to-back sales](#), and Sotheby's, [editorial on the white glove Mnuchin collection sale](#), totals for the week of May 18, 2026. ↵
9. ARTnews, [Phillips' 2024 sales figures](#), Christie's, [2024 global sales results](#), and The Art Newspaper, [Sotheby's 2024 results](#). ↵